countries would be participating. London's Punjabi community had turned up in full force and cheered me vociferously when I won race after race. The English gardener at the stadium was a fan of mine and would always wish me good luck before a race. 'Mr Singh, I want to see you win,' he would say, jumping up and down. After each win, I would give him a small tip.

While I was in England, I had received a special invitation from the Soviet Union to participate in a race in Moscow. This event was held in memory of the Znamensky brothers, Georgy and Seraphim, who, in the 1930s, were the Soviet long-distance champions. This tournament, first established in 1958, is today an annual event that draws athletes from all over the world. But when I went there in 1960, most of the participants were from Soviet Bloc countries, though there were a few sportspeople from Asia and Europe, including Korea, France, Norway and England.

That was also the era when the India–Russia Friendship Treaty was at its strongest, and wherever we went we would be greeted by cries of 'Rusi–Hindi bhai, bhai', and snatches of Hindi film songs. Raj Kapoor and Nargis were probably more popular in the Soviet Union then they were in India. Their film *Awara* had been released in 1951 and since then its actors were treated like glamorous celebrities. The Russian people had tremendous admiration for our country and I was astonished by how much they knew about our history, particularly the freedom movement and Independence, and leaders like Mahatma Gandhi and Nehru.

Nina, my English-speaking interpreter, was equally curious about India, and would keep asking me questions about the conditions of our workers and peasants. I was pleasantly surprised by the serious tone of her enquiries. Most other foreigners I had met seemed more interested in the more exotic aspects of India—elephants, maharajas, snake charmers, jugglers and mendicants. That's when it dawned upon me how different the Soviet Union was from Western countries .

Whenever I entered the Lenin Stadium, young boys and girls would run up to Nina, requesting her to get them my autograph, or asking me, through her, to tell them the story of my life and career. While listening to their eager questions, I contemplated on the meaning of fame. Adulation and glory can be a double-edged sword that can make or break a celebrity. In the world of sports, fans follow and cheer their favourites, particularly